

Sailing the seas

People first started traveling by water more than 10,000 years ago. To begin with, their boats were simple canoes and rafts propelled with oars or poles. Over time, vessels became bigger and more complicated, fitted with sails of fabric or animal skin to capture the power of the wind. This made longer voyages possible, so people had to invent devices that told them where they were and in which direction they were heading.



The three ranks of rowers were positioned so their oars did not strike each other.

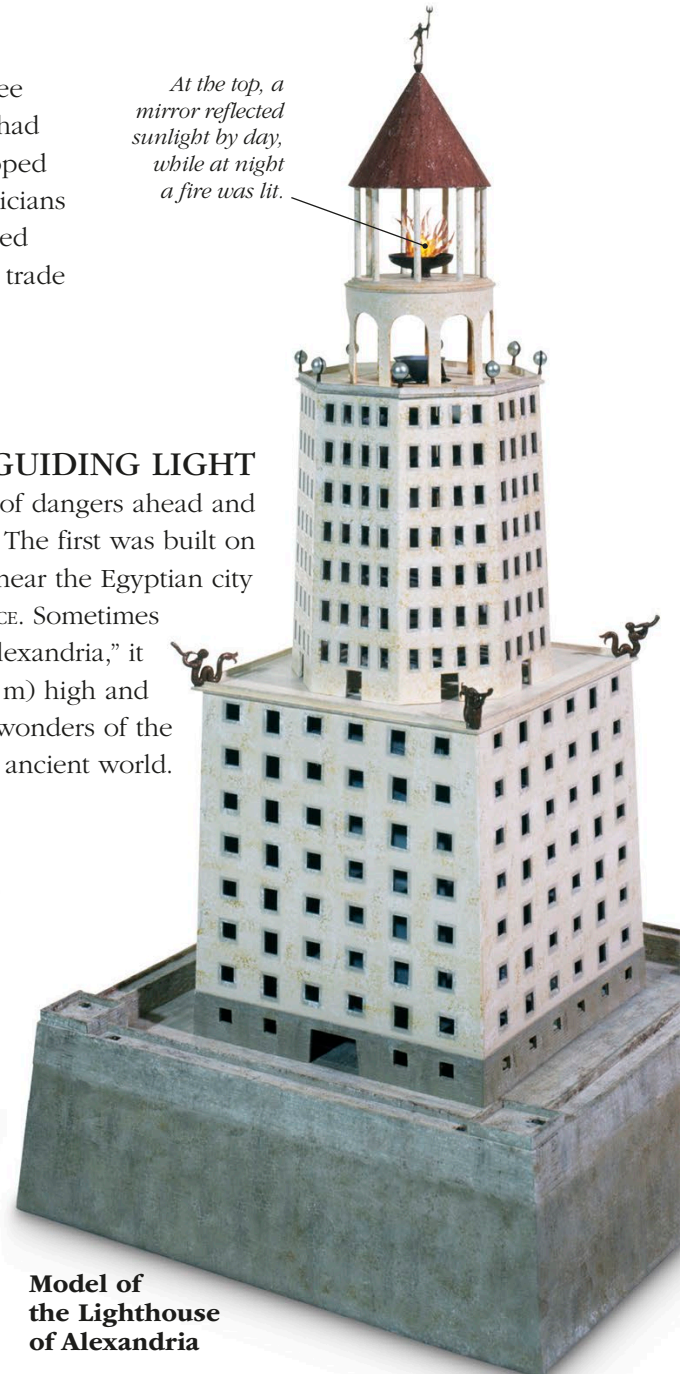
THE TRIREME

A ship mainly powered by three rows of oars, the trireme also had one or two sails. It was developed by either the Greeks or Phoenicians in around 700 BCE and it enabled both civilizations to travel and trade across the Mediterranean Sea.

At the top, a mirror reflected sunlight by day, while at night a fire was lit.

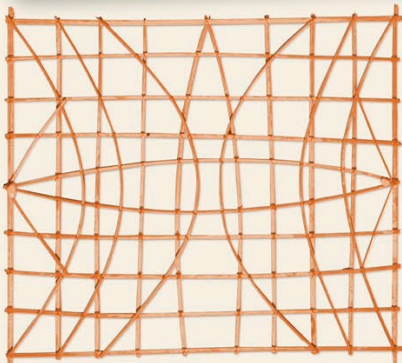
GUIDING LIGHT

Lighthouses warn ships of dangers ahead and help guide them to safety. The first was built on Pharos, a small island near the Egyptian city of Alexandria, in 280 BCE. Sometimes called the “Pharos of Alexandria,” it stood around 360ft (110m) high and was one of the seven wonders of the ancient world.



Model of the Lighthouse of Alexandria

POLYNESIAN STICK CHART



The Polynesian peoples navigated across the vast expanse of the South Pacific, sailing between islands that were hundreds of miles apart. They mapped the position of islands, atolls (rings of coral), and ocean currents using charts made of strips of dried coconut leaf, wood, and shell.